

Curriculum Subcommittee Notes - February 24, 2021

Roll Call - 3-0 - Chair -Van der Kloot,
Graham, Mustone

Technology and Library - Ms. Laden:

We follow K-12 - 2016 Frameworks

Tools are being used across all the grades

Skills that students need for day to day life

K-12 continuum

K-2, 3-5, 6-8 and 9-12

Digital Literacy & Computer Science per DESE

Technology is varied

K-2 safe use of devices, understanding of passwords, to protect privacy, responsible use, digital citizen - how to use a keyboard - how to use a browser - drawing tools - identify computing systems, tools for different tasks - intro coding, robotics (Beebots, Mice Bots), intro to G suite, microsoft office

Grades - 3-5 - using social media safely, security tech, cyberbullying - keyboards, G suite, online research - using numbers/letters to represent info, information organization, coding, robotics, data identification, manipulation, debugging

Grades - 6-8 - tech threats, privacy, responsible use, media literacy - information copyright - how to use online tools and information research/literacy - operating systems, components, robotics - app development

Grades 9-12 - Media Literacy, Computer Science Principles, Web Design, Digital Literacy & Student Tech help desk

Vocational School- Programming & Web Development, Robotics and Engineering, business Tech, Explorations in Computer Programming (Math)

Library curriculum - to promote literacy, to assist in fostering academic achievement, & create responsible digital citizens - hopefully our makerspace will open in library soon

K- 2- to help students understand library and develop love of books

Grades - 3-5 - develop their reading and research skills

Grades - 6-8 - Research thru print and internet online databases - diverse viewpoints, read books with diverse characters

Grades - 9-12 - advanced research, develop writing skills, research projects - Science Fair, World History Day, and prepare them for college level information skills

Future Goals - Library Makerspaces, Expansion of student tech help desk, bring Girls who Code Club to MPS and build course pathways, full time libraries in all schools with certified school librarians/tech integration leaders

Member Van der Kloot - any questions?

Member Graham - computer science curriculum? Or best practice of computer science instruction for 2020-2021

Ms. Laden - alignment specific with grade - align activities with standards - we see elementary once a week, so we hit key content standards for specific outcomes

Outcome based curriculum K-8

Set curriculum - 9-12

Member Graham - how often are computer classes in other districts?

Ms. Laden - some don't have it / some do a semester like we do at the middle school / some do it within the classroom

Member Graham - What are your recommendations for our students to be successful?

Ms. Laden - not the # of times we see the students - it's not a stand alone - its embedded in the students day - writing on the computer for example - using a slide show to present a science project - tech teachers had to teach proficiency with keyboards for MCAS - use it throughout the day - and now extremely important that everyone has a chromebook

Member Graham - new curriculum?

Ms. Laden - I don't think so - so this year and last year - we have supported staff and students how to use google classrooms, emails, online research tools - some of those things will continue to evolve depending on needs - more a skill set than a set curriculum

Member Graham - you are suggesting it's a good shift - but nothing is going to change? Budget decisions - computer science learning support? -resources Sourced through PTO's?

Ms. Laden - computer use in general or computer
Massive influx of tech funding - we are fully teaching online - devices are available for every student/staff - continuing to replace and do maintenance - maintaining - replacement budget & staffing levels - continuing tech support in the district

Member Van der Kloot - how do we support our classroom teachers - are we doing enough to support our teachers in areas they don't feel comfortable with google classroom, etc?

Ms. Laden - Library & Tech teachers work hand in hand with classroom teachers - reinforcing and assisting when needed

Member Graham - I'm surprised in grades 3-5 - I've never seen that in the library -is in the general education classroom or actually in the library?

Ms. Laden - Both - library staff is stretched thin - library is working with content teachers

Member Graham - will we look for an ask for proper staffing of libraries?

Ms. Laden - We did expand Librarian paras, but we'd like to expand obviously I've asked every year, maybe it didn't get to you

Member Graham - please make sure your "asks" get to us

Member Van der Kloot - tech issues? How do we assist those who might have difficulties? Do they come in?

Ms. Laden - we are a little understaffed - we are doing more replacement than repairs - so we have the devices to do that - but we will give them out - we are also giving out hotspots as well - breakage? In the last few days, that's increasing as the school year goes on - we are doing exchanges as things break - high school students will keep their student device - use for testing etc.

Member Van der Kloot - Are they breaking at the normal wear & tear

Ms. Laden - More home breakage - younger students - but breakage is relatively low

Member Van der Kloot - will we hire for Frank's position?

Ms. Laden - It's posted

Member Van der Kloot - other things we will need to be aware of for your budget request this year?

Ms. Laden - The ordered chrome tablets for K finally arrived as did the document cameras for teachers - (2) instructional labs would need upgrading - for coding - we would look to build in a replacement budget for the future

Mr. Amici - coding curriculum for middle school?

Ms. Laden - app development curriculum - code.org at middle schools - approved curriculum for math at high school

Dr. Ricciardelli - World Language Dept - several members of department on call - Vilma Bibeau - lead teacher - plays important role in department - I'm covering this position and overseeing Fine Arts

Topics - Landscape

Frameworks -

Offerings

Where are we going from here?

A lot of research about the importance of learning a language - higher academic achievement on tests = learning a new language, increased respect for cultural diversity - can help one understand their 1st language - in the global economy and the importance of knowing other languages. Current "Foreign Language" Frameworks - 1999 - BO ED will be voting on new frameworks of 2021 - Even though the frameworks are old, our department is on the cutting edge of world languages - focusing on grammar and proficiency - our instruction is more interactive - less book work especially in grades 6-12 - students should feel confident about what they can do, rather than what they don't know - methodology over textbooks - less focus on textbooks - they aren't adopted yet, but the new focus - social emotional learning/cultural connection - we have been doing in Medford for awhile

No more elementary program - with no more funding from Cast It
Teacher for AP Italian Course - financed through grant from Italian Consulate

Languages Offered Include:

Middle - Italian, Spanish / High school - French, Italian, Spanish and for the Vocational School, online courses are available for them - just can't fit into their vocational school schedule

Some High school electives: Spanish for Spanish speakers, Latin American Music, Contemporary Issues in Latin America/Spain, etc

Current enrollments middle school - 455 Spanish / 247 Italian
MHS - French - 100 / Italian - 148 and Spanish - 314

I have asked that French be offered in the middle schools

Member Van der Kloot - with doing away of Italian in middle school?

Member Graham - Is it true that some middle school students placed in Italian due to overwhelming numbers in Spanish?

Dr. Ricciardelli - to my knowledge every student in grade 6 got their 1st choice - you may have heard other things - I do have the preference sheets that we follow, on file.

Member Graham - we are saying people are choosing it, rather than being enrolled?

Dr. Ricciardelli - there was no attempt to fill classes, driven by students requests - or sometimes a student's schedule wouldn't allow it - if we could bring French in that would give parents another option

Member Graham - how do you do 5 years of french in high school?

Dr. Ricciardelli - we do have several students who speak french already, so they don't start in French 1 - or some students double up

Ms. Bibeau - our heritage students take it or are already proficient - we give them a test and then the student is place in level they should be in

Dr. Ricciardelli - Mass core - 2 years of same language - MHS grad requirement - we do require a minimum of 2 years of same language - MA state college system - requires 2 years of a language, some private colleges require 3 years

Ms. Bibeau - Seal of Biliteracy - proficiency in English as well as one or more additional languages for our seniors - we try to encourage our EL students - it is a test - 4th year - 34 students hopefully this year will take exam - Additionally, students can test in Chinese, Arabic, French, Italian - basically test in English and another language - if achieve proficiency score - rewarded with State Seal of Biliteracy - and placed on their transcript - some colleges are actually beginning to accept this as credit

Member Mustone - 522 total students taking languages- does Vocational School have the same requirement?

Dr. Ricciardelli - but due to scheduling for Voke - (6) in Italian, (4) in french and But it can be waived if needed for college - but it's online until we have a different schedule we have to take this route

Member Graham - Why do Vocational students have to take a language?

Dr. Ricciardelli - Structural part of their schedules - schedule is driven by the contract - limited in options - each class meets every day - just hard to do that with the Vocational schedule - our teachers are constantly in touch with the students - it is a function of the structural schedule

Member Graham - is there a change coming?

Dr. Ricciardelli - I was on a team, 2 years ago, that tried to change it but we could not come up with an agreement of how it could work

World Language Offerings Across in Mass:

Spanish - 92.6%

French - 67.2%

Latin - 38.2%

Mandarin - 23.1%

Italian - 11.1%

German - 7.4%

ASL - 6.3% (*however not considered a world language credit in colleges)

Portuguese - 5.1%

Greek - 2.6%

Arabic - 1%

Surrounding Districts Offer:

Arlington - French, Italian, Latin, Mandarin, Spanish

Everett - Italian, Latin, Spanish

Malden - French, Italian, Spanish, Latin
Melrose - French, German, Italian, Latin, Spanish
Somerville - French, Italian, Portuguese, Spanish
Winchester - French, Italian, Latin, Mandarin, Spanish

So Medford is comparable

We sent out 2 surveys

1 - in the spring of 2020 - grade 5 parents only - 52% wanted spanish - 30% said if french was offered 18% italian first choice

2 - parents could add in a different choice

ASL - it would be a wonderful addition, but it doesn't count towards a college language

If we did French - I'd add in at grade 6 - and we wouldn't need additional staff

Member Mustone - grade 6 for French - hard to find french teachers?

Dr. Ricciardelli - we have teachers on staff that can teach more than one language - we do have to look at what students want - teachers can go from Andrews to McGlynn if needed

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Thank you to Bernadette & Molly for their presentations - let the data do the talking - I'd agree I'd like to offer French at middle school level it is a good option to continue in high school - maybe do a survey - for scheduling

Dr. Ricciardelli - only offer to grade 6 is my take on it

Member Van der Kloot - it's unfortunate that we can't provide an introduction to another language at a younger age - I'd love to have a bilingual program within our schools from K-12

Member Graham - we did pass a recommendation to offer another language at elementary level that we didn't get to today and that is on the table as well

Ms. Nyland - I'm one of the French teachers at MHS - we'd have a higher number of level 5 French students if we offered it in middle school - I've surveyed - a lot of students would take it in middle school - glad that French is offered online for voke students

Motion to adjourn by Member Graham, seconded by Member Mustone

Roll Call - 3-0 - at 5:30 PM

